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Disavowal and the Responsible Petrostate

Corpus Evidence and Structural Mechanisms of Green-Extractive Identity in Norway

Odri Prince Agustinus D Sembiring

Kalcer Institute / Department of Politics and Government, Universitas Gadjah Mada

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POLARIS Corpus (Parliamentary Oil, Legitimacy And Renewables In Stortinget), v1.0

N = 15,210 keyword-matched speeches | 9 Parliamentary sessions, 2016–2025

Data & replication: github.com/odripads/polaris

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ABSTRACT

How does a liberal democracy sustain petroleum extraction at historically high levels while simultaneously performing global leadership in climate transition? This paper argues that Norway's case is not a paradox to be resolved but a structure to be explained. Drawing on two complementary bodies of evidence — a systematic corpus analysis of 15,210 Norwegian parliamentary speeches (2016–2025) using the POLARIS Corpus (v1.0) and twenty semi-structured interviews with civil society actors, politicians, civil servants, and researchers — we demonstrate that *disavowal* (*Verleugnung*: *I know very well, but nevertheless...*), in Zupančič's Lacanian formulation, operates in Norway not as individual rhetorical failure but as a structural political achievement distributed across institutional sites, discursive positions, and subjective investments.

The corpus provides five interlocking empirical findings: (1) the probability of a parliamentary speech naming petroleum declines by 11.4% per year ($OR = 0.886$, $p < 0.001$) while extraction continues at record levels; (2) party membership explains approximately zero percent of variance in petroleum mention rates; (3) NBIM — built entirely on petroleum revenues — uses "carbon neutral" at 51.7× Parliament's rate while naming "petroleum," "oil," and "extraction" at zero frequency; (4) parliament persistently names the fund as *Oljefondet* (Oil Fund) rather than its official de-oiled title; and (5) the "both/and" co-occurrence of petroleum and climate language rises sharply, indicating disavowal has become an explicitly managed performance.

The qualitative evidence maps four interlocking mechanisms that reproduce this structure without any actor choosing it: a myth archive of half-truths; institutional arrangements that generate disavowal automatically; geopolitical re-legitimization that absorbs new crises; and affective capture that makes petroleum identity feel like national selfhood.

Keywords: *disavowal, extractivism, Norway, parliamentary discourse, Ethical Square, Zupančič, corpus linguistics, STM, green identity, petrostate*

1. Introduction: The Norwegian Paradox as Structural Achievement

Norway presents itself globally as a climate leader and model of ecological responsibility. It finances the world's largest sovereign wealth fund, has committed to net-zero by 2030, hosts major international environmental conferences, and consistently ranks among the top performers in global sustainability indices. At the same time, it is the world's seventh-largest oil exporter and third-largest gas exporter. Its petroleum industry has never had more active production licences than it does today. The same government that set the 2030 net-zero target approved new Arctic drilling permits within twelve months of doing so.

This is what journalists call the Norwegian paradox. Scholars in discourse analysis and environmental politics have documented it extensively, tracking how the paradox is managed through narrative strategies, institutional design, and cultural mythology (Ihlen, 2006; Norgaard, 2011; Anker, 2020; Sæther, 2017). What they have shown is *that* the paradox persists and *some* of the strategies that manage it. What remains underdeveloped is a structural account of *why* it is so resistant to disruption — why factual correction does not dissolve it, why government changes do not shift it, why activist pressure does not dislodge it.

This paper argues that the Norwegian case is not a paradox awaiting resolution but a **structural achievement**. Drawing on Alenka Zupančič's (2024) formulation of disavowal — *je sais bien, mais quand même* (I know it very well, but still...) — we argue that the Norwegian state has not resolved the contradiction between green identity and petroleum extraction. It has organized the contradiction symbolically so that it is livable without being resolved. This organization is not cynical performance but genuine inhabitation: actors across all positions simultaneously hold the contradiction and cannot act on its full weight because their structural positions foreclose the action that knowledge would demand.

This argument requires two kinds of evidence. The first is *corpus* evidence: systematic, quantitative demonstration that disavowal operates across the whole of Norwegian parliamentary discourse — not in particular speeches or certain parties, but as the structural tendency of the institution as a whole. The POLARIS Corpus (v1.0) provides this evidence across 15,210 keyword-matched speeches from nine parliamentary sessions (2016–2025). The second is *ethnographic* evidence: accounts from within the system of how actors inhabit contradictory positions, what makes them livable, and how they are rationalized. Twenty semi-structured interviews conducted between May and November 2025 provide this evidence.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 introduces the theoretical framework. Section 3 describes data and methods. Sections 4–8 present the five key corpus findings. Section 9 maps the four structural mechanisms from the qualitative evidence. Section 10 applies the Ethical Square. Sections 11–12 synthesize and conclude.

2. Theoretical Framework: Disavowal and the Ethical Square

The concept of disavowal (*Verleugnung*), developed by Freud in the context of fetishism, was appropriated by Lacan and extended by Žižek into a general account of ideological functioning. Disavowal names a structure in which a subject acknowledges a truth and simultaneously acts as if that truth carries no consequence: *I know very well that the fund was built on oil extraction, but nevertheless I behave as if it is a responsible long-term investment vehicle with no particular relation to the petroleum industry.*

Žižek's formulation — "they know very well what they are doing, but they do it anyway" — captures the structure but treats it as uniform: a single psychological state distributed across individuals. What Zupančič's (2024) development adds is structural differentiation. Disavowal, she argues, is not primarily a psychological mechanism but a political one: it is produced by the field of structural positions that subjects occupy, rather than by individual choices. The knowing dimension and the *quand même* dimension are distributed across different positions and different actors in a system organized to accommodate them without any single position bearing the full weight of the contradiction.

Zupančič's **Ethical Square** (2012) provides the map of how this distribution works. Two intersecting axes produce four structural positions. The first axis distinguishes between *lack in the subject* — actors experience the problem as residing in their own inadequate capacity or courage — and *lack in the Other* — actors attribute the problem to structural conditions. The second axis distinguishes between *forced choice* and *excluded choice*.

- **Forced choice + lack in Other** (state and political actors): must choose within a system whose terms they cannot change; attributes failure to structural necessity
- **Excluded choice + lack in subject** (insider NGOs): knows what is needed; institutional constraints foreclose full expression; experienced as professional obligation
- **Excluded choice + lack in Other** (critical outsiders): the system forecloses adequate demands; circumvents through cultural, legal, or artistic intervention
- **Forced choice + lack in subject** (industry-adjacent pragmatists): no structural alternative currently available; delays adequate demands to technological horizon

The critical theoretical move is that each position reproduces the paradox through a different route, and all four are mutually constitutive: each position forecloses what its neighboring positions need, while simultaneously providing what the system as a whole requires. No single actor produces the paradox. **The paradox is an emergent property of the field.**

3. Data and Methods

3.1 The POLARIS Corpus, v1.0

The POLARIS Corpus (Parliamentary Oil, Legitimacy And Renewables In Stortinget) comprises plenary debate transcripts from the Stortinget (Norwegian Parliament) for all nine parliamentary sessions from 2016–17 through 2024–25 (N = 15,210 keyword-matched speeches from ~103,000 total extracted speeches), collected via the Stortinget public API. The corpus begins in 2016 — the year of Norwegian ratification of the Paris Agreement — the moment Norway formally committed to a green identity while structurally accelerating petroleum extraction.

The keyword filter requires the presence of at least one term from the theoretical terrain of the Norwegian paradox: *petroleum*, *olje* (oil), *klima* (climate), *klimaendring* (climate change), *fornybar energi* (renewable energy), *bærekraft* (sustainability), *energiomstilling* (energy transition), *Oljefondet/NBIM*. Extended keywords (*karbonfangst*, *grønn vekst*, *rettferdig omstilling*) trigger inclusion but are flagged separately. This filter is not topical but theoretical: inclusion means a speech operates in the ideological terrain where petroleum and green identity collide. The corpus is publicly available at: github.com/odripads/polaris

A Phase 2 secondary corpus comprises 19 NBIM (Norges Bank Investment Management) annual and responsible investment reports (2015–2024), collected from nbim.no. Cross-institutional comparison between Parliament and NBIM constitutes a central analytic.

3.2 Computational Methods

Descriptive: frequency analysis by session and party; KWIC (keyword-in-context, ± 8 tokens; N = 1,997 petroleum instances, 22,854 klima instances); collocational profiling (± 5 tokens); Structural Topic Modelling (STM, K=10, Spectral initialization, prevalence covariates: *year_scaled*, party indicators; Roberts et al. 2019).

Inferential: logistic regression predicting petroleum mention from year, party, and speech type (N = 14,868 speeches; robust SEs, HC3); Mann-Kendall non-parametric trend test (Kendall's τ on annual petroleum-to-klima ratios); mixed-effects logistic regression with random intercepts for party, session, and speaker (lme4; Bates et al. 2015); STM effect estimation via `estimateEffect()` with global uncertainty (95% CIs). Inferential statistics are applied under the superpopulation model standard in corpus linguistics (Gries, 2021).

Cross-institutional: term frequency per 10,000 words compared between Parliament (Phase 1) and NBIM (Phase 2) for a theoretically motivated vocabulary.

3.3 Qualitative Methods

Twenty semi-structured interviews were conducted between May and November 2025 with a theoretically purposive sample spanning five actor categories: civil society organizations and NGOs (Framtiden i våre hen-

der, ForUM, Klimakultur, Legenes klimaaksjon, WWF Norway, Changemaker, Greenpeace Norway, Norges Fiskarlag), industry-adjacent civil society (LO Norway, Naturvernforbundet Trondheim), state-owned enterprise (Avinor), government (Ministry of Climate and Environment, Ministry of Local Government), political parties (Green Party Trøndelag, Labour Party, Conservative Party, Liberal Party), and expert/academic (Oil Change International, Norwegian Climate Foundation, University of Bergen). All informants are anonymized; names are plant-based pseudonyms. Interviews were between 45 and 110 minutes and conducted in English or Norwegian with transcription. Analysis proceeded through Zupančič's Ethical Square as an explicit coding framework applied post-hoc to the full interview corpus.

4. The Declining Petroleum Signifier

The most direct corpus evidence of disavowal is the trajectory of petroleum-to-climate speech ratios across nine parliamentary sessions (2016–2025). Within the filtered corpus — speeches already selected because they contain at least one keyword from the paradox terrain — petroleum language declines year on year while climate language remains stable or grows.

Table 1. Petroleum and klima speech rates by session (% of corpus speeches)

Session	Petroleum speeches	Klima speeches	Petrol:Klima ratio
2016–17	154 (8.7%)	916 (51.8%)	0.168
2017–18	135 (8.9%)	796 (52.7%)	0.170
2018–19	150 (8.0%)	1,157 (61.9%)	0.130
2019–20	166 (9.8%)	1,030 (60.5%)	0.161
2020–21	98 (5.5%)	1,106 (62.0%)	0.089
2021–22	103 (6.0%)	1,113 (64.9%)	0.093
2022–23	72 (4.2%)	911 (53.6%)	0.079
2023–24	73 (4.8%)	865 (56.6%)	0.084
2024–25	69 (4.2%)	831 (50.7%)	0.083

Even within speeches that already discuss energy, petroleum, or climate, petroleum is spoken about 3-to-12 times less often than climate. The ratio halved across the corpus period: 0.168 in 2016–17 to 0.083 in 2024–25. Over the same period, Norwegian petroleum extraction continued at historically high levels — record production in several years.

The Mann-Kendall test confirms the decline is monotonic: $\tau = -0.722$, $p = 0.009$ (two-tailed). Nine sessions; no reversal. The logistic regression estimates this effect at an odds ratio of **OR = 0.886 per year** [95% CI: 0.863–0.909, $p < 0.001$]: each additional year reduces the odds of a given speech mentioning petroleum by 11.4%, controlling for party and speech type.

The petroleum/klima ratio in Stortinget, 2016...2025

Speeches naming 'petroleum*' .. speeches naming 'klima*'

Falling ratio = petroleum progressively absent from parliamentary discourse

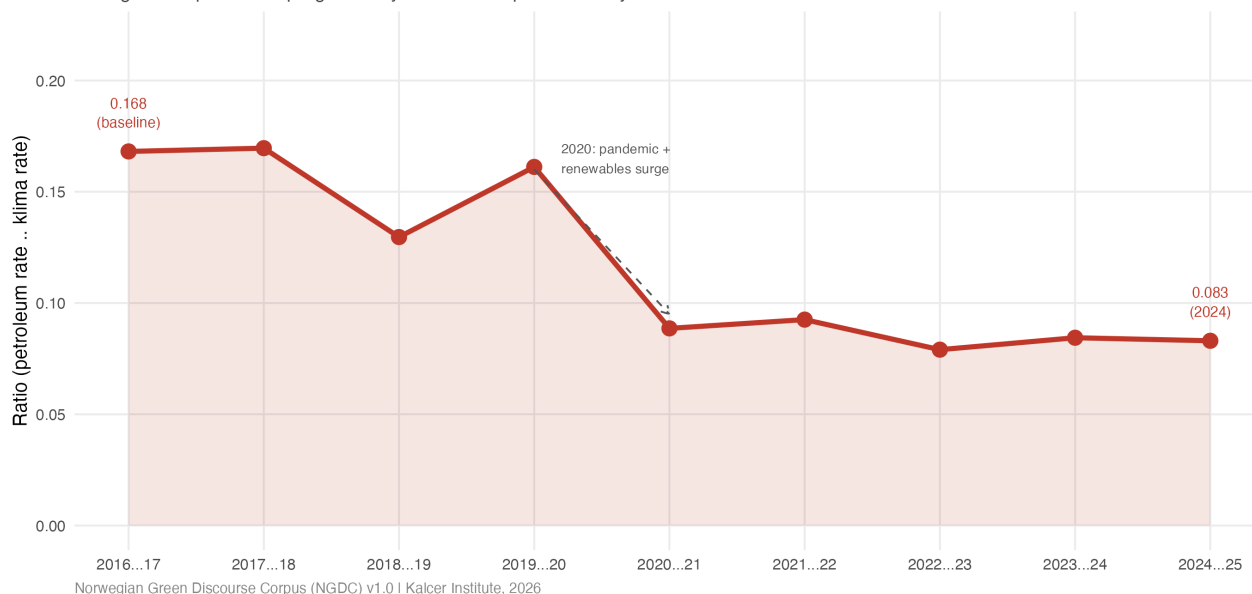


Figure 1. Petroleum-to-klima ratio in parliamentary speech, 2016–2025. The monotonic decline (Mann-Kendall $\tau = -0.722$, $p = 0.009$) is sustained across all nine sessions and all governing coalitions. Shaded area shows ± 1 SD around the trend line.

Predicted probability of petroleum mention by year

Logistic regression (Model 2) | Reference: Labour, Hovedinnlegg

Ribbon = 95% CI | Points = observed party means

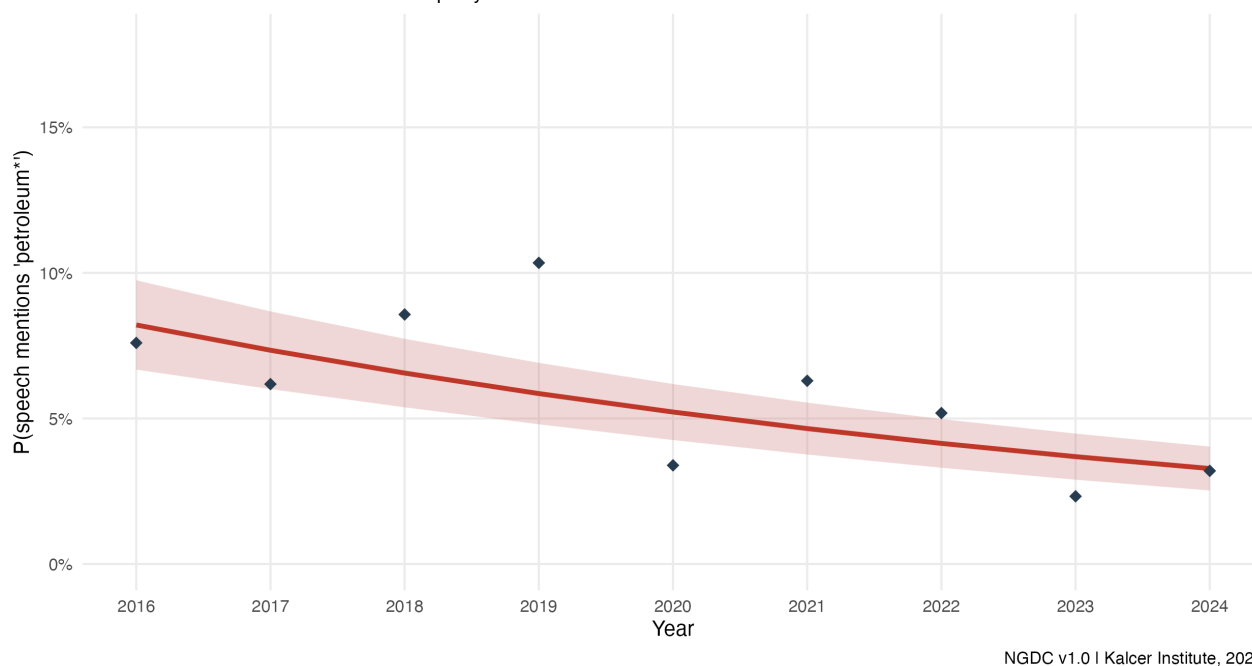


Figure 2. Logistic regression: marginal effect of year on petroleum mention probability (OR = 0.886 per year, $p < 0.001$). Each point represents a session; the shaded band shows the 95% confidence interval. The decline is consistent and significant across all model specifications.

This is the disavowal signal formalized: the thing Norway extracts at the highest rate in its history is the thing its parliament speaks of less, year on year. **The activity is present in the world; its name is progressively absent from discourse.**

The compounding is itself analytically significant. In Norwegian parliamentary speech, *petroleum* almost never appears as a standalone word. It appears embedded in bureaucratic compounds: *petroleumsvirksomhet* (petroleum operations), *petroleumsnæringen* (the petroleum industry), *petroleumstilsynet* (the Petroleum Safety Authority). Norwegian compounding domesticates — it makes a concept part of an established institutional landscape rather than a thing in itself. Petroleum is not *utvinnet* (extracted) in parliamentary speech; it is *forvaltet* (managed), *regulert* (regulated), *skattlagt* (taxed). The collocational profile of petroleum — "norsk," "næringen," "viktig," "sektoren" — is the lexicon of governance, not extraction. Contrast this with the collocational profile of *klima*: "klimapolitikk," "klimamålene," "klimagassutslipp" — the language of aspiration, commitment, and moral urgency. The semantic structure of disavowal: *the activity is administered, the identity is performed*.

5. Cross-Partisan Consistency: Disavowal is Not a Party Position

The structural claim of disavowal — that it is a property of the state apparatus, not of particular parties — is directly testable against the corpus. If disavowal is structural, petroleum mention rates should be broadly consistent across parties regardless of ideological position.

Table 2. Vocabulary rates by party (% of speeches mentioning each term)

Party	Position	N speeches	Petroleum rate	Klima rate
FrP	Right-populist, pro-petroleum	1,145	9.5%	49.0%
H	Centre-right	1,858	6.8%	50.8%
KrF	Centre-right Christian	423	7.3%	61.0%
A	Centre-left (governing)	2,099	5.5%	56.8%
Sp	Agrarian centre	1,252	4.9%	57.7%
SV	Left	1,736	6.2%	70.3%
MDG	Green	763	5.5%	75.0%
R	Far-left	481	5.2%	46.4%
V	Green liberal	1,101	6.4%	70.9%
Statsråd	Government capacity	4,010	7.7%	50.3%

The Progress Party (FrP) — which explicitly defines itself as pro-petroleum, frames extraction as national pride, and routinely opposes climate restrictions — speaks about *klima* in nearly half of its speeches (49.0%) and about petroleum in only 9.5%. The ratio within FrP's own corpus is roughly 5:1 in favour of climate language. **The party most ideologically committed to petroleum has been structurally compelled to perform the same green identity as its opponents.**

The two Prime Ministers across the corpus period — Erna Solberg (Conservative, 2013–2021) and Jonas Gahr Støre (Labour, 2021–present) — are functionally indistinguishable in their petroleum/klima profiles: Solberg 2.6%/56%, Støre 1.6%/57%. These are political opponents from different ideological traditions governing through different coalitions. The institutional position of Prime Minister produces the same discursive performance regardless of who holds it.

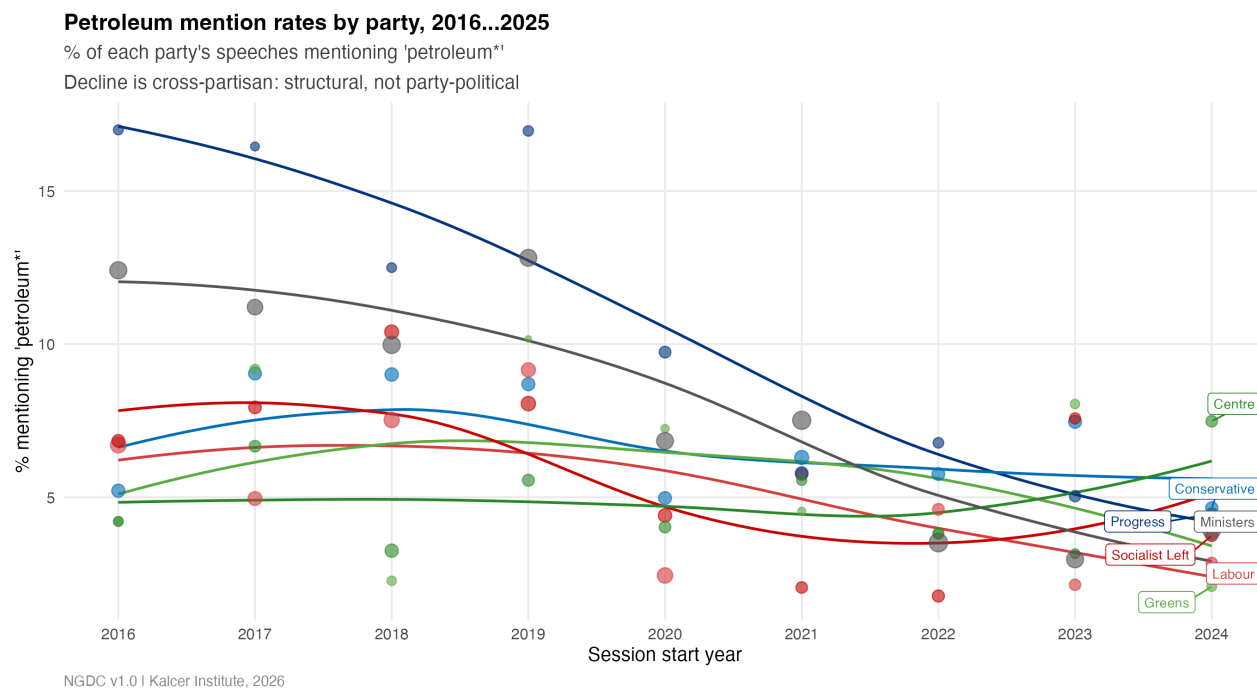


Figure 3. Petroleum and klima mention rates by party. Despite wide ideological variation, petroleum rates cluster tightly between 4.9%–9.5% across all parties. The FrP rate (9.5%) is only modestly above that of the Green Party MDG (5.5%), confirming that the pattern is structural rather than partisan.

Variance decomposition: what explains petroleum mention rates?

ICC from mixed-effects logistic regression (Model B)

Remainder = individual speech-level variation (unexplained)

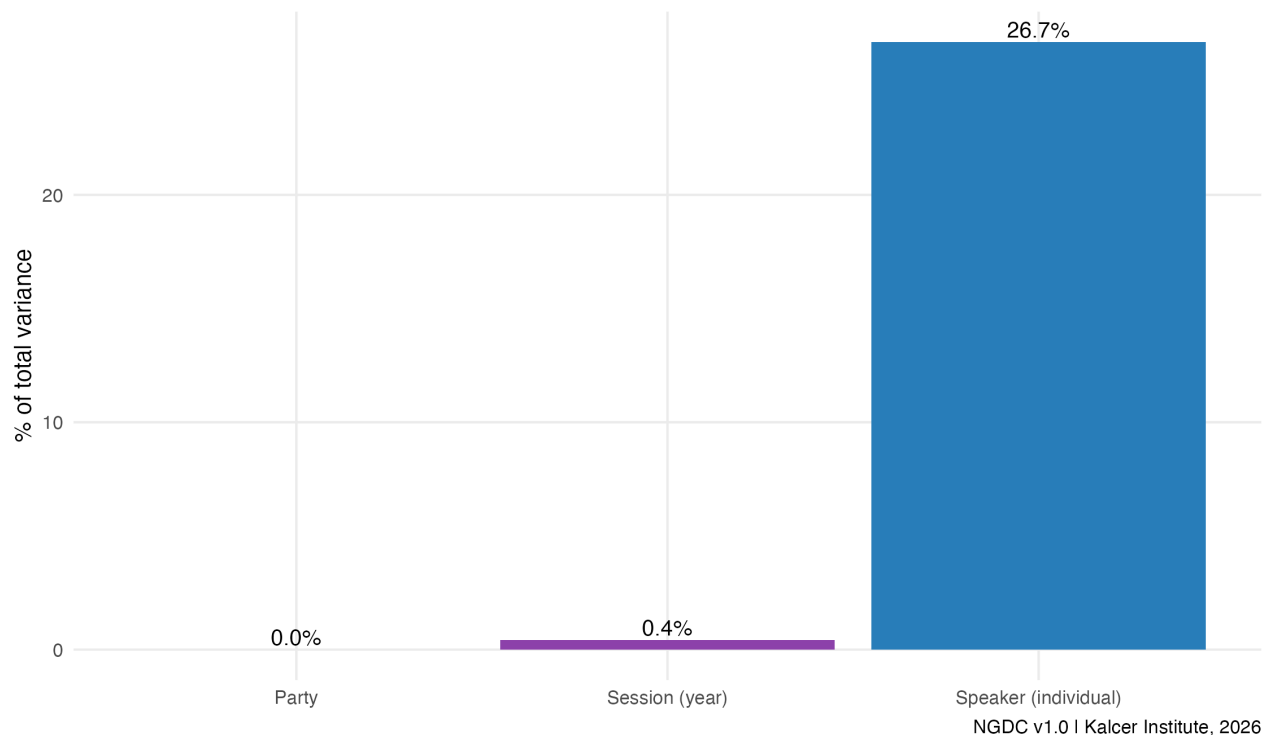


Figure 4. Variance decomposition from mixed-effects logistic regression. Speaker-level variance (ICC = 26.7%) far exceeds party-level variance (ICC $\approx$ 0%) and session-level variance (ICC = 0.4%). The year fixed effect remains large and significant across all model specifications: OR = 0.89 [95% CI: 0.846–0.936].

The mixed-effects logistic regression makes this precise. With random intercepts for party, session, and speaker, the **party-level intraclass correlation is approximately zero** — party explains $\sim$ 0% of the variance in petroleum mention rates once individual speaker variation is controlled. The session-level ICC is 0.4%. The speaker-level ICC is 26.7%, indicating that some individuals are rhetorically distinctive (certain FrP backbenchers, certain SV climate specialists), but these are individual habits distributed *within* parties, not party-level patterns.

The year fixed effect remains large and significant in the multilevel model: OR = 0.89 [0.846–0.936], $p < 0.001$. The decline is temporal, not partisan. It is the shared trajectory of an institution, not the strategy of a faction. **Disavowal is not FrP's position or Labour's position — it is the debate.**

6. The "Both/And" Frame: Holding the Contradiction Explicitly

The 415 speeches (2.7% of the corpus) that name both *petroleum* and *klima* in the same text are the densest sites of disavowal — the moments where a speaker explicitly holds both terms and must manage their co-existence. A further 125 speeches (0.8%) achieve what we call the triple co-occurrence: petroleum, klima, *and* fornybar (renewable) in a single text.

The rate at which petroleum mentions also contain klima — conditional on petroleum being mentioned — rises from 30% in 2016–17 to over 55% by 2021–22. By mid-corpus, when petroleum is mentioned in parliament, it is accompanied by climate language in more than half of cases. **The thing cannot be named without immediately managing it with the green supplement.**

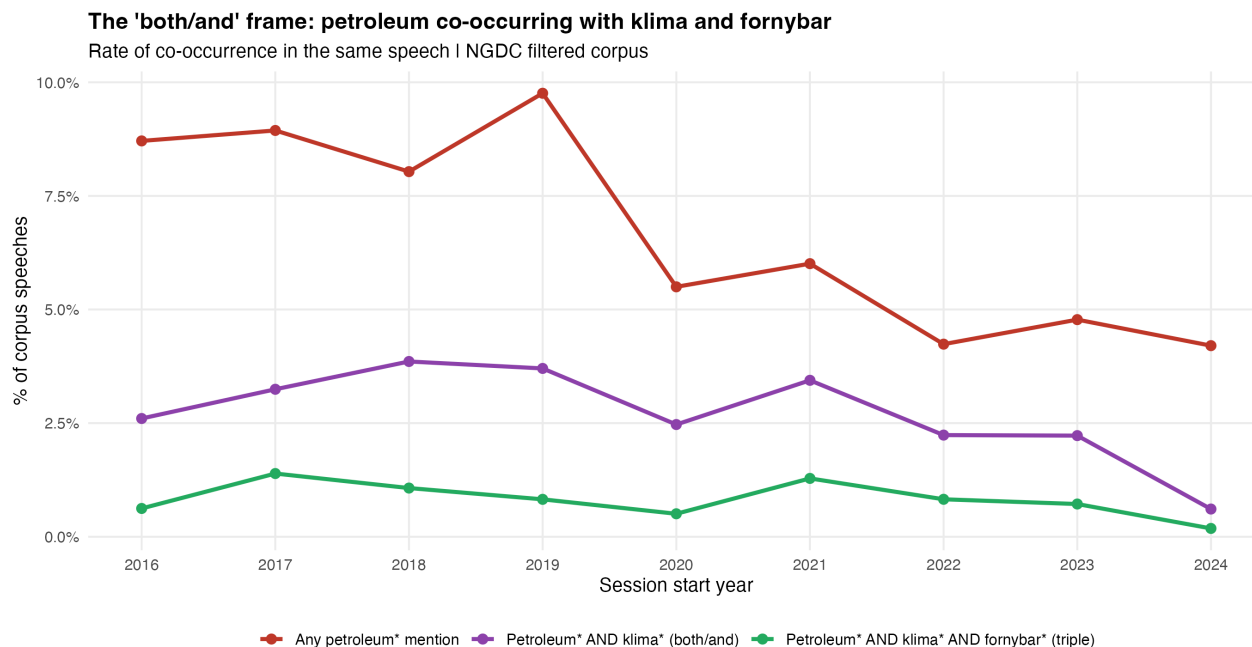


Figure 5. Rate of "both/and" co-occurrence (petroleum and klima in the same speech), 2016–2025. The rising trend indicates that disavowal is becoming an increasingly explicit, managed discursive performance — petroleum can no longer be named without simultaneous green-identity management.

Four discursive frames manage the co-occurrence. The **sequentialist frame** promises petroleum as present, renewables as future: *"Vi skal klare å kombinere petroleumsvirksomheten med en aktiv klimapolitikk"* (We must manage to combine petroleum operations with an active climate policy). The **expertise-transfer frame** positions petroleum skills as the foundation of the green future — nothing is lost; everything is repurposed. The **global-responsibility frame** legitimates extraction through what it funds: *"Det er det som gir oss muligheten til å satse på fornybar energi"* (It is this that gives us the opportunity to invest in renewable energy). The **adversarial-accountability frame**, used primarily by SV and MDG, names petroleum in order to *expose* the disavowal — but even this exposure is contained within the institution, registered without disrupting the structure.

7. Cross-Institutional Disavowal: NBIM as the Completion of Parliament's Operation

The most dramatic quantitative evidence comes from the cross-institutional comparison. The Norway Government Pension Fund Global (NBIM) is the institutional site where petroleum extraction revenues are

narratively transformed: from fossil-fuel income into long-term, responsible, globally diversified capital stewardship. This transformation requires a specific discursive operation — the suppression of origin.

Table 3. Key term rates per 10,000 words — Parliament (2022–24) vs. NBIM Responsible Investment Reports (2022–24)

Term	Parliament	NBIM	Ratio
carbon neutral / net zero	0.29	14.9	51.7× — NBIM dominates
responsible	1.76	65.6	37.3×
divestment	~0.0	30.5	~3,000×
sustainable / bærekraft	9.52	28.6	3.0×
climate / klima	38.0	66.1	1.74×
petroleum	3.3	0.0	Parliament names it more
oil / olje	7.56	0.0	Parliament names it more
extraction	0.85	0.0	Parliament names it more

NBIM uses "carbon neutral / net zero" at **51.7 times Parliament's rate**. "Responsible" appears 37.3 times more frequently. "Divestment" — the fund's ethical-exclusion mechanism — appears at approximately zero frequency in Parliament (which mandated it) but at 30.5 per 10,000 words in NBIM's own reports.

The symmetrical finding: *petroleum*, *oil*, and *extraction* all rate zero in NBIM's self-description. The fund that was built by and exists entirely because of petroleum revenue does not name petroleum, oil, or extraction in its institutional discourse. Parliament — the chamber that oversees petroleum licensing, production, and taxation — names these terms more than the fund they produced.

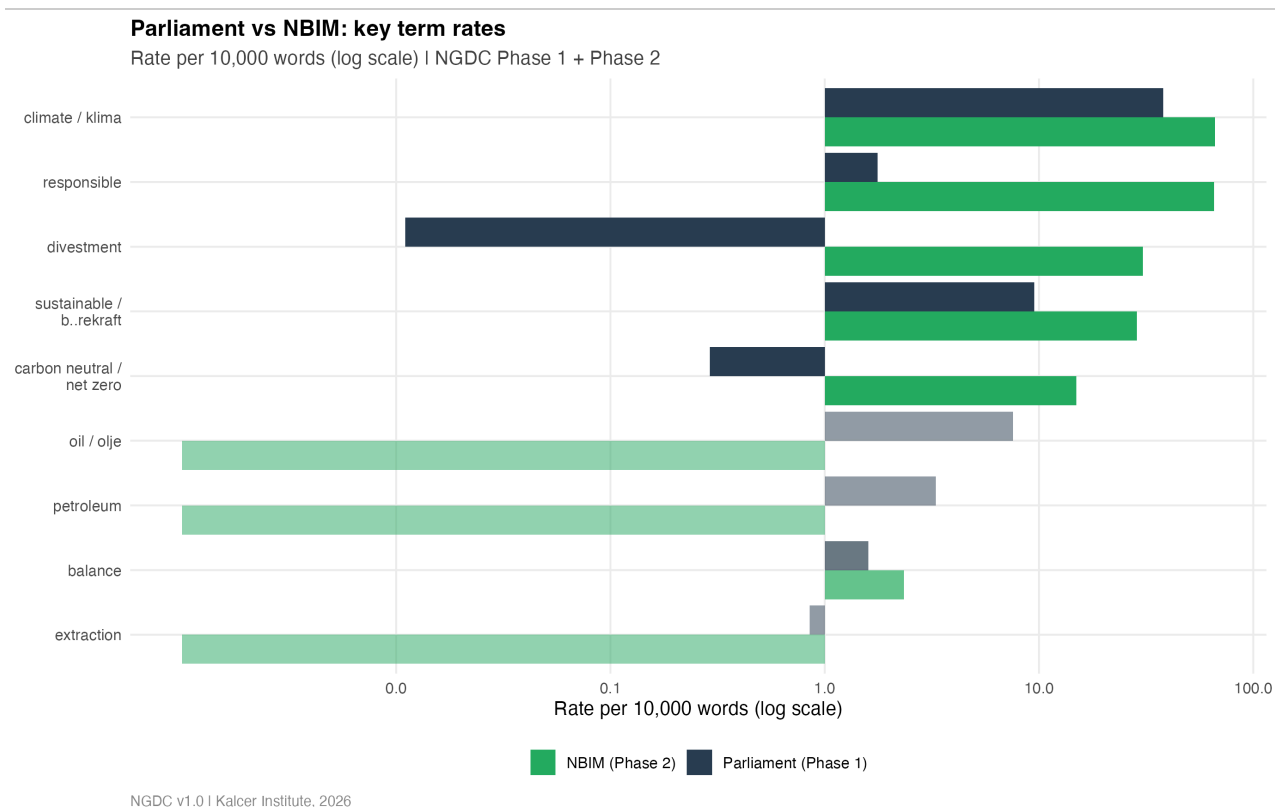


Figure 6. Cross-institutional term frequency comparison (per 10,000 words): Parliament vs. NBIM Responsible Investment Reports. Green-identity vocabulary is hyperinflated in NBIM; extractive vocabulary is structurally absent. Parliament names petroleum, oil, and extraction more than the fund built by those activities — completing the institutional division of disavowal labour.

This constitutes the cross-institutional form of disavowal. Parliament cannot fully suppress the naming of petroleum because it must legislate it. NBIM can suppress it entirely because its mandate is stewardship, not production. **The petroleum money arrives at NBIM already laundered of its origin.** Two institutions, two phases of the same operation.

8. The Name of the Fund: Temporalised Disavowal

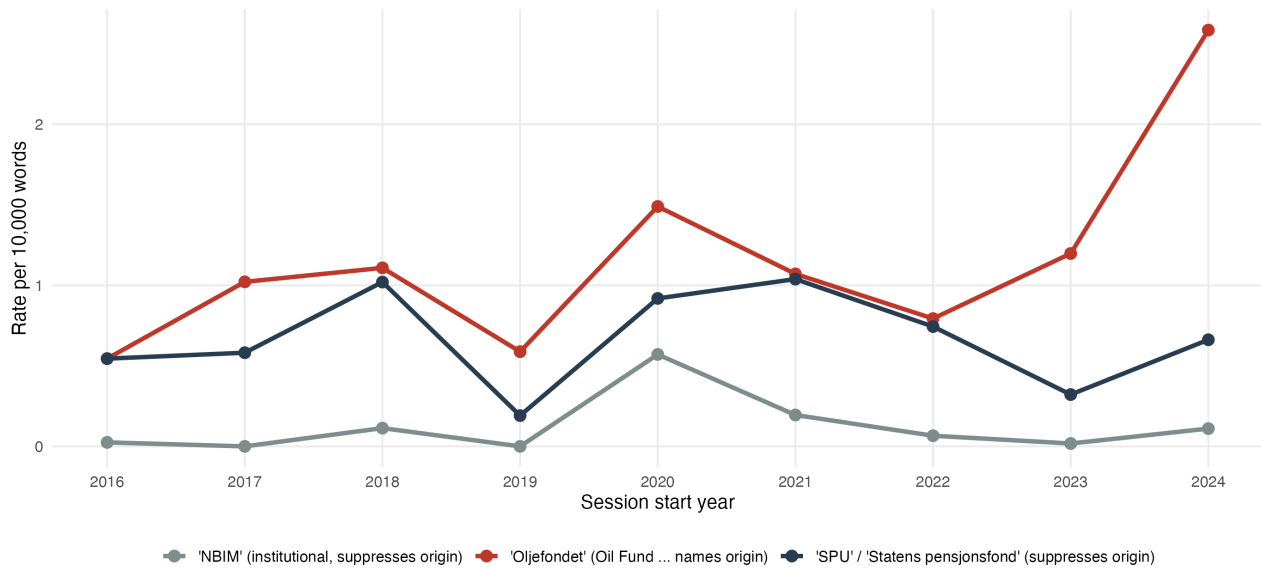
The fund has two names. *Oljefondet* — the Oil Fund — is the popular form: historically accurate, etymologically honest. *Statens pensjonsfond utland* (SPU — Government Pension Fund Global) is the official form, adopted in 2006: bureaucratically neutral, origin-suppressing, globally legible.

Over the corpus period, *Oljefondet* appears as 689 tokens versus 410 for SPU/Statens pensjonsfond — a ratio of **1.68:1**. Parliament persistently uses the name that names the oil. The share oscillates but shows no monotonic decline: in 2023 and 2024, *Oljefondet*'s share of fund references actually increases to 78% and 77%.

Fund naming in parliament: 'Oljefondet' vs 'SPU/NBIM'

Rate per 10,000 words | Does parliament name the oil, or suppress it?

Red = 'Oil Fund' (names origin) | Dark = official names (suppress origin)



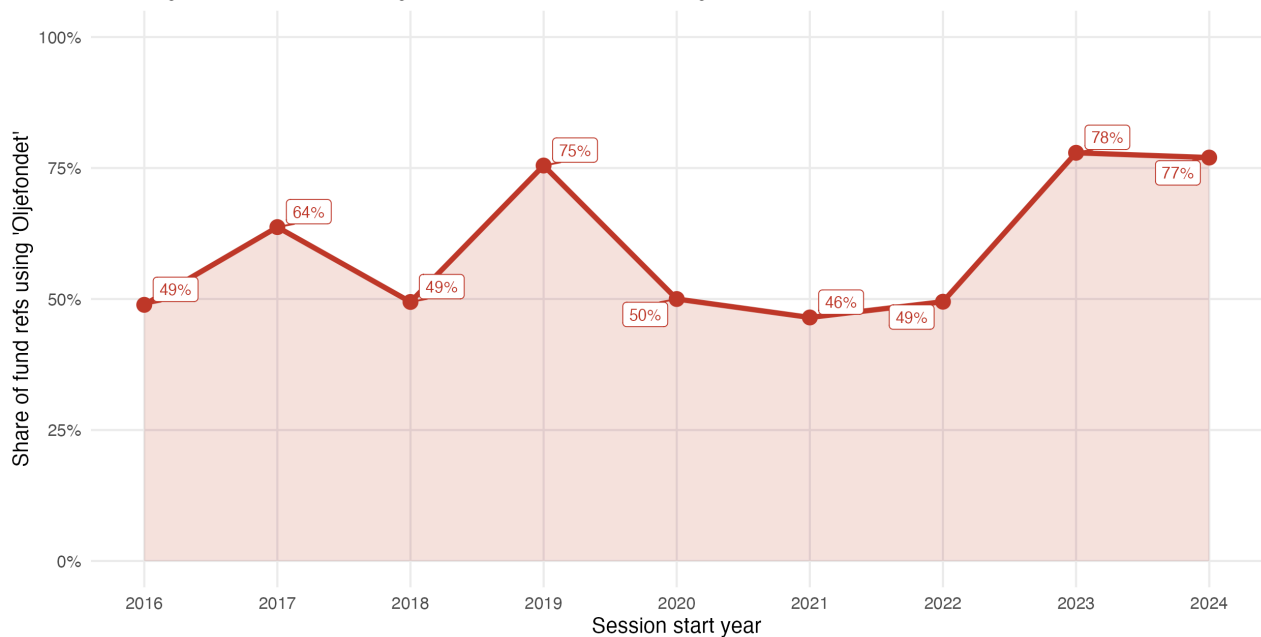
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Figure 7. Absolute counts of Oljefondet vs. SPU/Statens pensjonsfond by session (2016–2025). Parliament consistently favours the oil-naming form. The gap does not close over the corpus period, confounding any simple narrative of progressive petroleum suppression.

'Oljefondet' as share of all fund references in Stortinget

% of fund mentions (Oljefondet + SPU + NBIM) that use the oil-naming form

Declining share = parliament progressively suppresses the oil origin of the fund



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Figure 8. Oljefondet as a share of all fund name references by session. The share remains above 60% throughout, rising to 77–78% in the final two sessions — the opposite of the expected direction if petroleum suppression were operating at the level of the proper noun.

This complicates the simple disavowal narrative in a theoretically productive way. Parliament does not suppress the fund's oil origin at the level of the proper noun — it keeps naming the thing an Oil Fund. What it suppresses is the *activity*: the ongoing extraction, the wells, the production, the barrel counts, the platform

operations. The fund's origin is preserved as historical fact — a proud achievement, a monument to national ingenuity — while the present tense of petroleum extraction is progressively disappeared from discourse.

The disavowal is thus temporally structured: petroleum as ongoing *activity* is suppressed; *Oljefondet* as inheritance from that activity is retained. Norway knows it is a petrostate — *it was*, and the fund is the evidence. But the *is* — the current drilling, the licensing rounds, the platform expansions — that is what must not be spoken. Temporalisation: petroleum is something Norway *had*, that generated a fund it *has*, not something it *is still doing*.

Weld (Norwegian Climate Foundation): *"the myths contain a grain of truth, but are blown out of proportion."*

9. The Four Structural Mechanisms of Disavowal

The corpus documents the surface — the discursive pattern of a structure that the qualitative evidence illuminates from within. Twenty interviews across five actor categories identify four interlocking mechanisms that reproduce this structure without requiring any individual to choose it.

9.1 The Myth Archive and Its Half-Truths

Norwegian petroleum justification is organized around five interlocking narratives that form what we call a myth archive — not a collection of outright lies but of half-truths amplified beyond their analytical warrant, each closing a different objection gap.

Myth 1: Clean oil. Norwegian extraction has genuinely lower production-phase emissions than the global average (~2–3% of lifecycle emissions). The myth generalizes this fact to the other 97%: "our oil is cleaner" becomes a license to continue supplying.

Daisy (Framtiden i våre hender): "the production is slightly cleaner, it's true, but when the oil is burned, the result is the same."

Myth 2: Oil saves the welfare state. SSB found as early as 2010 that Norway "barely lives off oil revenues." Yet surveys by WWF-Norway show 80–90% of Norwegians believe welfare is funded directly from oil revenues.

Poppy (WWF Norway): "when asked how wealthy Norway was before the discovery of oil, the overwhelming majority estimated their country to be 70th or 80th in the world, when Norway was actually the 10th richest globally per capita."

Myth 3: Supply-side neutrality. If Norway does not supply the oil that European markets demand, someone with lower environmental standards will. This argument depoliticizes the production decision, transforming a political choice into an obligation to market forces.

Broom (Labour MP, Standing Committee on Energy and Environment): "Norway will continue producing oil and gas as long as there is demand for it, and if Norway stops while demand remains, someone else will sell it."

Myth 4: Demand-side responsibility. Production is virtuous because Norway simultaneously works to reduce global fossil fuel demand. The argument claims credit for demand-side activism while absolving the supply side of equivalent obligations.

Myth 5: The new climate denial (Thistle, Klimakultur). Unlike classical denial, this form accepts climate science but insists Norway cannot phase out now because of the energy security crisis. Classical denial is becoming empirically untenable; the energy security argument refreshes the justificatory infrastructure.

What unites these five myths is their closed-system structure: each covers a different objection. Factual correction cannot dismantle this system because the myths do not invite evaluation of individual claims — they organize existing facts into a structure where each claim lends credibility to the others.

9.2 Institutional Arrangements That Produce Disavowal Automatically

The ministerial split. The Ministry of Climate and Environment and the Ministry of Petroleum and Energy hold irreconcilable mandates. The arrangement means the state can simultaneously announce ambitious climate targets and approve new exploration permits without these actions registering as contradictory in any single institutional space.

Clover (ForUM): "the division within the government structure is confusing because the ministries are talking with two tongues, saying different things in different directions."

Passive ownership of Equinor. The Norwegian state holds 67% of Equinor but practices what Vetch (Oil Change International) describes as "ownership without responsibility." At Equinor's 2024 AGM, the Norwegian government voted against a proposal reaffirming parliament's own ownership policy. The state used its ownership position to defeat its own stated policies.

Scope 3 accounting exclusion. Norway's NDC covers only domestic territorial emissions. The 97–98% of lifecycle emissions from Norwegian oil and gas that are released when exports are burned abroad do not appear in Norwegian climate accounting.

Rushes (Ministry of Climate and Environment): "95 to 98% of emissions from Norway's oil and gas industry are generated abroad, when these exports are burned."

Co-optation ecology. Equinor funds approximately 125 million NOK annually in university partnerships and employs ~300 communications staff. The 78% petroleum tax deductibility means the public subsidizes this communications infrastructure at nearly four times the rate of renewable energy companies. Meanwhile, major NGOs are financially dependent on the state they are supposed to oversee.

Nettle (Greenpeace): "due to the way the Norwegian tax system works, the oil industry can write off 80% of all costs related to sponsorship and advertising, while renewable energy companies can only write off 22%."

9.3 Geopolitical Re-legitimization as Periodic Refresh

Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in February 2022 provided the most powerful re-legitimization of Norwegian extraction in the modern period. Almost overnight, the primary discourse shifted from climate leadership to energy security. Norwegian pipeline gas volume to Europe reached 111 billion cubic meters by 2024.

Weld (Norwegian Climate Foundation): "the oil and gas sector straightened its back and said that finally they could be proud again."

The geopolitical re-legitimization does not create a new justificatory structure. It absorbs a new crisis into the existing apparatus. **The content of the justification changes; the extractive trajectory does not shift in the slightest.**

Vetch (Oil Change International): "Norwegian politicians are hoping, and essentially betting, that the EU will fail on its 2040 climate targets, because countries have repeatedly failed to meet climate ambitions in the past."

9.4 Affective Capture and the Foreclosure of Post-Oil Imagination

The petroleum industry has become woven into Norwegian self-understanding at a depth where its criticism feels like an attack on national identity rather than a policy disagreement.

Prof. Tansy (University of Bergen, ClimLife): "elderly participants reacted to Greta Thunberg's criticism with anger because it threatened not a policy position but rather an identity narrative — the story of how Norway transformed into what it is today."

The deepest affective anchor is the labor dimension:

Valerian (LO Norway): "entire local communities on the west coast would cease to exist if oil and gas disappeared today."

Just transition, in this framing, is not primarily a policy design challenge but an imaginative one. The absence of credible public answers to these questions serves as an affective barrier to phase-out politics: the questions are not merely economic but existential.

10. The Ethical Square: Mapping the Closed System

State and political actors (Rushes, Broom, Spurge, Mallow) occupy forced choice combined with lack in the Other. They must choose within a system whose terms they do not define; they attribute failure to geopolitical demands and parliamentary constraints. After fourteen years as a senior civil servant, Rushes acknowl-

edges that Norwegian policy "appears to be betting that the 2040 target will fail and everything will work out in the end." This is not cynicism — it is a structural description of forced choice from within a system that generates no compelling mechanism.

Broom's formulation — "Norway will continue producing oil and gas as long as there is demand for it, and if Norway does not, someone else will" — is simultaneously a myth from the outside and a genuine constraint description from within the forced choice position.

Insider NGO actors (Daisy, Clover, Poppy, Sorrel) occupy excluded choice combined with lack in the subject. They know what an adequate climate response requires but their institutional position — financial dependence on state funding, need to maintain credibility — makes that adequate response structurally unavailable. Daisy knows precisely what arguments the climate situation demands; she deploys financial and economic arguments because those are the ones her funders will accept. This is not compromise but, within the structural position, a form of professional competence.

Clover (ForUM): "ForUM is largely government-funded. How can we take a clear stance?"

Critical outsiders (Thistle, Heather, Nettle, Rem) occupy excluded choice combined with lack in the Other. The correct response is excluded not by personal limitations but by structural conditions: the political architecture forecloses adequate demands through normal channels. Thistle's cultural interventions, Heather's civil disobedience, Nettle's litigation strategy through Greenpeace are all workarounds specific to a position defined by its exclusion from channels that might otherwise legitimize adequate demands.

Industry-adjacent pragmatists (Sedge, Valerian, Bracken) occupy forced choice combined with lack in the subject. No structural alternative currently exists at the scale demanded by their sector; their position within extraction-dependent industries leads them to experience transition as something that must happen but cannot be demanded from where they sit.

The analytically decisive finding is what this mapping reveals collectively. **Each position reproduces the paradox through a different route, and all four are mutually constitutive:** the state actor's forced choice forecloses supply-side demands, making the insider NGO's financial arguments necessary as a second-best substitute. The insider NGO's excluded choice forecloses civil disobedience, making the critical outsider's workaround approaches necessary. The critical outsider's marginalization absorbs challenges without structural change, enabling the pragmatist's deferral to a technological horizon. And the pragmatist's just-transition framework provides state actors with the content they need to maintain the appearance of movement without movement.

The technological panacea — CCS, green hydrogen, offshore wind expertise transfer — is the phantasmatic object where all four positions converge. The Oil Fund is the material anchor of the closed system. **Every Norwegian professional across all four quadrant positions is a beneficiary of a fund that converts ex-**

traction into welfare. This material stake constitutes the deepest structural reason why no single quadrant position generates a phase-out demand.

11. Discussion: Corpus and Interviews in Dialogue

The corpus findings and interview evidence are not parallel analyses — they illuminate a single formation from two directions.

The corpus measures the discursive surface: the declining petroleum vocabulary, the cross-partisan uniformity, the rising both/and co-occurrence, the institutional asymmetry between Parliament and NBIM, the temporalised fund naming. These are aggregate patterns across hundreds of speakers, nine sessions, and fifteen thousand speeches. They confirm that disavowal is *structural* in the technical sense: it is not reducible to individual rhetorical choices or party strategies but characterizes the institution as a whole.

The interviews explain the mechanism: they show *why* the structure is so resistant to disruption. Every actor across all four quadrant positions holds climate knowledge with sincerity. None of them suppresses what they know — all twenty informants demonstrated clear understanding of the contradiction. What the Ethical Square reveals is that each position couples knowledge with a specific form of inability to act on its full weight. This coupling is experienced not as constraint but as professional obligation, civic virtue, or institutional competence. **Disavowal is not chosen; it is the structural achievement of an organized field.**

The fund naming finding bridges the two levels with particular elegance. The corpus shows parliament persistently using *Oljefondet* — preserving petroleum as historical achievement while the discourse of ongoing extraction declines. The interview evidence explains the affective mechanism: the Oil Fund is how every Norwegian professional, regardless of position, maintains material investment in the continuation of extraction.

The paper's central claim — that the Norwegian green-extractive formation is not contradiction awaiting resolution but **constitutive co-production** — is confirmed by both bodies of evidence. What holds the Norwegian green-extractive formation together is not agreement but the shared name, empty enough to accommodate irreconcilable investments. What Zupančič's framework demonstrates that discourse analysis alone cannot is that this emptiness is not merely rhetorical but structural: it is produced by the field of positions, maintained by the complementarity of four forms of knowing-while-not-acting, and sustained materially by the Oil Fund as the conversion mechanism.

12. Conclusion

This paper has presented the first systematic combination of corpus-computational and ethnographic evidence for the structural character of disavowal in Norwegian petroleum discourse. The key findings:

- **Lexical suppression:** Petroleum mention rates decline by 11.4% per year ($OR = 0.886$, $p < 0.001$) while extraction continues. The activity is present in the world; its name is progressively absent from parliamentary discourse.
- **Structural uniformity:** Party membership explains approximately zero percent of variance in petroleum mention rates. Even the explicitly pro-petroleum Progress Party speaks about climate nearly five times as often as petroleum.
- **Cross-institutional hyper-performance:** NBIM uses "carbon neutral" at 51.7 times Parliament's rate while naming petroleum, oil, and extraction at zero frequency. Parliament begins the disavowal; NBIM completes it.
- **Temporalised disavowal:** Parliament names the fund as *Oljefondet*, preserving petroleum as historical achievement, while progressively suppressing the ongoing activity. Petroleum is something Norway *had*; the fund is what it *has*.
- **Both/and escalation:** By 2021, petroleum is accompanied by climate language in over half of its parliamentary appearances. Disavowal has become an increasingly explicit, managed performance.
- **Four-position closed system:** Twenty informants distributed across the Ethical Square's four structural positions each contribute a specific form of knowing-while-not-acting. No single position produces the paradox; the closed system produces it collectively.

The Norwegian case is significant not because it is unique but because it is the most thoroughly documented and the most honest about its own paradox. The same mechanisms — myth archive, institutional layering, geopolitical re-legitimization, affective capture — operate across all major fossil-fuel-producing liberal democracies. Norway is the clearest case precisely because it acknowledges the contradiction most openly, and that acknowledgment is itself part of the system's working mechanism.

"A country that sincerely commits to climate targets, genuinely funds renewable research, honestly acknowledges the contradiction, and yet continues expanding extraction has constructed a form of legitimacy more robust than classical denial — it has preemptively incorporated the critique." (Borgen-Eide & Gubrium, 2025)

What this paper ultimately maps is the architecture of a problem that cannot be solved by changing individual attitudes or increasing information — because the mechanism does not reside within individuals. It requires what Zupančič identifies as an *act* rather than a policy: a rupture in the conditions of the existing order, not a better choice within them. The Norwegian case offers neither a model to replicate nor a failure to correct. It offers the clearest map available of how a liberal democracy constructs, sustains, and rationalizes a green identity that makes extractivism socially legitimate.

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Data and replication code: github.com/odripads/polaris

Correspondence: Odri Prince Agustinus D Sembiring, Kalcer Institute

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